WEEK 13: COMMITTED ACTION - BUILDING YOUR RECOVERY PLAN

Committed Action: Values into Behavior

You've spent the last few weeks clarifying your values, practicing acceptance, and learning to defuse from difficult thoughts.

Now it's time to turn values into action.

Committed action is one of the six core processes of ACT. It means:

- Taking action guided by values, not feelings
- Moving toward what matters even when it's uncomfortable
- Building patterns of behavior that align with who you want to be
- Acting despite fear, anxiety, or urges

THE KEY INSIGHT:

You don't have to feel ready to take action.

Most men wait until:

- The urge goes away
- They feel motivated
- They're confident they can succeed
- The fear subsides

ACT says: You can feel anxious, unmotivated, fearful, or have urges AND still take values-based action.

"Do what works" principle: Does this action move me toward my values or away from them?

Behavior Change Requires More Than Insight

Understanding your cycle, your triggers, your cognitive distortions—all of that is important.

But **insight alone doesn't create change.**

You need:

- **Clear values** (you've identified these)
- **Concrete goals** (you're creating these today)
- **Small, consistent actions** (this is the work)
- **Self-compassion with setbacks** (not perfection)

SMART Goals Framework

SMART goals turn vague intentions into concrete action plans.

S - SPECIFIC What exactly will I do? (Not "be better," but "call my accountability partner every Monday at 7pm")

M - MEASURABLE How will I know I did it? (Clear evidence, no ambiguity)

A - ACHIEVABLE Is it realistic given my current circumstances? (Not "never have an urge again")

R - RELEVANT Does it align with my values? (Connected to what matters)

T - TIME-BOUND When will I do it? By when? (Specific timeframe)

VAGUE INTENTION VS. SMART GOAL:

Vague: "I'll work on my recovery."

SMART: "I will attend one support group meeting every Tuesday at 7pm for the next 4 weeks, and I will arrive 10 minutes early to connect with other members."

- **Specific:** Support group, Tuesdays, 7pm, arrive early
- **Measurable:** Did I attend? Did I arrive early?
- **Achievable:** Yes, I have Tuesdays free
- **Relevant:** Connects to my value of connection and support
- **Time-bound:** Next 4 weeks

EXERCISE 1: CREATING SMART GOALS

Create 3 values-based SMART goals:

GOAL #1: THIS WEEK

Value this connects to: _____

My SMART goal for this week:

_____

_____

_____

Specific: What exactly will I do?

_____

Measurable: How will I know I did it?

_____

Achievable: Is this realistic this week?

_____

Relevant: How does this align with my values?

_____

Time-bound: When will I do this?

_____

_____

GOAL #2: THIS MONTH

Value this connects to: _____

My SMART goal for this month:

_____

_____

_____

Specific: What exactly will I do?

_____

Measurable: How will I know I did it?

_____

Achievable: Is this realistic this month?

_____

Relevant: How does this align with my values?

Time-bound: When will I complete this?

GOAL #3: NEXT 3 MONTHS

Value this connects to: _____

My SMART goal for the next 3 months:

Specific: What exactly will I do?

Measurable: How will I know I did it?

Achievable: Is this realistic in 3 months?

Relevant: How does this align with my values?

Time-bound: By what date?

High-Risk Situation Planning

You know your triggers. You know your high-risk situations. Now you need specific action plans for each one.

The principle: Don't wait until you're in the situation to figure out what to do. Plan now, while you're calm.

EXERCISE 2: HIGH-RISK SITUATION ACTION PLANS

Identify your top 3 high-risk situations and create an action plan for each.

HIGH-RISK SITUATION #1

What is the situation?

What makes this high-risk for me? (triggers present, past patterns, etc.)

My committed actions when this situation arises:

Before the situation (if possible):

During the situation:

1.
2.
3.

After the situation:

Potential barriers: What might prevent me from following this plan?

How I'll handle barriers:

Who can support me?

HIGH-RISK SITUATION #2

What is the situation?

What makes this high-risk for me?

My committed actions when this situation arises:

Before the situation (if possible):

During the situation:

1.
2.
3.

After the situation:

Potential barriers:

How I'll handle barriers:

Who can support me?

HIGH-RISK SITUATION #3

What is the situation?

What makes this high-risk for me?

My committed actions when this situation arises:

Before the situation (if possible):

During the situation:

1.
2.
3.

After the situation:

Potential barriers:

How I'll handle barriers:

Who can support me?

Barrier Troubleshooting

Even with good plans, barriers arise. Anticipating them increases your chance of following through.

Common barriers to committed action:

"I don't feel like it"

- Feeling follows action, not the other way around
- Take action based on values, not feelings
- Ask: "Will I feel better after I do this, or after I avoid it?"

"I don't have time"

- Recovery must be a priority, not something you fit in
- What are you saying "yes" to that you need to say "no" to?
- What can you delegate, eliminate, or postpone?

"I'm afraid I'll fail"

- Failure is data, not defeat
- Every attempt teaches you something
- Progress isn't linear

"It's too hard right now"

- Hard doesn't mean impossible
- Discomfort is part of growth
- You can do hard things

"I'll start tomorrow"

- Tomorrow never comes
- What small action can you take right now?
- Momentum builds from action, not intention

EXERCISE 3: MY BARRIER PLAN

What barriers am I most likely to encounter?

Barrier #1: _____

How I'll respond: _____

Barrier #2: _____

How I'll respond: _____

Barrier #3: _____

How I'll respond: _____

The Role of Accountability

You don't have to do this alone. Accountability dramatically increases follow-through.

Accountability means:

- Someone knows your plan
- Someone checks in on your progress
- Someone encourages you when you struggle
- Someone celebrates your wins

Accountability does NOT mean:

- Someone controlling you
- Someone shaming you for mistakes
- Someone being responsible for your recovery

EXERCISE 4: MY ACCOUNTABILITY SYSTEM

Who will I ask to be my accountability partner(s)?

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____

What do I need from my accountability partner?

How often will we connect?

What will I share with them?

What will I NOT share with them? (boundaries)

Weekly Action Tracker

This week, track your committed actions daily. Notice what makes it easier or harder to follow through.

Day	Values-Based Action I Took	Was It Difficult? (Y/N)	What Helped?	Barriers I Faced
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				

At the end of the week:

What made it easier to take committed action?

What made it harder?

How did taking values-based action affect my urges or mood?

What did I learn about myself?

The Difference Between Motivation and Commitment

MOTIVATION is a feeling. It comes and goes.

- "I feel inspired to change"
- "I'm excited about recovery"
- Feels good, but unreliable

COMMITMENT is a choice. It stays regardless of feelings.

- "I will do this even when I don't feel like it"
- "This matters, so I'm showing up"
- Doesn't always feel good, but it's reliable

Recovery requires commitment, not motivation.

You'll have days when you don't feel motivated. Days when you're tired, discouraged, or overwhelmed.

Committed action means showing up anyway.

Small Steps vs. Big Leaps

Don't underestimate the power of small, consistent actions.

Small steps work because:

- They're achievable (less overwhelming)
- They build momentum
- They create new neural pathways
- They prove to yourself you can do it

Examples of small steps:

- Call one person from your support network
- Practice urge surfing for 5 minutes
- Write one thought record
- Go for a 10-minute walk
- Journal for 5 minutes

- Read one page of this workbook

The compound effect: Small actions, done consistently, create massive change over time.

DAILY MONITORING LOG - WEEK 13

Continue your daily monitoring. This week, add focus on committed action.

Additional tracking:

- What committed actions did I take today?
- Did I follow through on my SMART goal?
- What barriers did I encounter?

[7 daily logs with same format as previous weeks—see Appendix A for blank forms]

WEEK 13 HOMEWORK CHECKLIST

Before moving to Week 14, complete:

- [ ] Read all Week 13 material
- [ ] Create 3 SMART goals (this week, this month, next 3 months)
- [ ] Develop action plans for 3 high-risk situations
- [ ] Complete barrier troubleshooting
- [ ] Identify and reach out to accountability partner(s)
- [ ] Take at least one values-based action every day this week
- [ ] Complete weekly action tracker
- [ ] Complete daily monitoring logs for all 7 days
- [ ] Notice: What makes committed action easier? What makes it harder?

Notes for Week 13:

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END OF WEEK 13